



## NILE'S TRIAL

NILE BIJOUX



## PORTAL TO ANOTHER WORLD

With PlayStation's latest tech, Niles Bijoux discovers sometimes not-quite-perfect can still be pretty good.

**S**ony has added another arrow to its quiver of PlayStation accessories. The PlayStation Portal is a bespoke device that allows you to play your PlayStation 5 games without a TV, as long as you have Wi-Fi. And it's pretty good – if not quite perfect.

To use the Portal, you need a PS5 and a strong, stable internet connection. Then you simply enable remote play, pair the Portal to the PlayStation, and off you go. You can use it at your local café, on the bus, anywhere you want. Like the name suggests, it's literally a portal to your PlayStation at home.

The Portal is extremely easy to set up and use, and if your internet is grumpy it streams games really nicely. It also works fine over mobile hotspotting, which is awesome. There's really no reason why it shouldn't, provided you're on at least 4G, but it adds another layer to the portability sell.

The eight-inch screen is vibrant and crisp, and while the spacing between the handgrips initially looks weird after using a regular PS5 controller for so long, it actually feels great to use. Sony has given the Portal the full DualSense 5 feature-set, which includes the spectacular haptic triggers.

All of that means, unlike other methods of using the PlayStation's Remote Play – say, your phone with a third-party controller – it genuinely feels like you're playing a handheld PlayStation.

Playing games is surprisingly lag-free as well, for the most part. Sure, you won't get the high refresh rate or HDR colours of a new TV, but games feel snappy and responsive, which is more important.

However, there are a few gripes. Some are small, like the system taking quite a while to link up with the PlayStation and the fact you can't watch Netflix on it, while some are just weird, like the absolute lack of Bluetooth functionality. Sony has sort of

covered itself by offering a 3.5mm jack (what? In 2024?) and you can always use your Pulse Explore buds through PlayStation Link, but they cost the same as the Portal. Surely it wouldn't cost much to add Bluetooth...

I also found the connection between console and Portal to be shaky, even if the internet connection

was stable. Games suddenly stopped registering inputs and the quality tanked until the connection either came back or was dropped entirely.

Plus, if you're like me and have physical copies of games in a desperate attempt to hold onto some

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long-lost part of childhood involving actual discs, the Portal makes less sense because you can't switch the discs while out and about. At the moment, Sony doesn't let you convert disc games to digital either, so you're pretty stuck if you're out and bored with the one game you've got inserted.

So while the PS Portal is genuinely great at what it does, it's ultimately a hamstrung device. Without a solid internet connection, it does nothing. You can't play anything from the Portal itself, you need a PS5 with, ideally, a bunch of digital games already downloaded. But if you already tick the boxes, it's a worthwhile, surprisingly affordable addition to your PlayStation armoury.

**PLAYSTATION  
PORTAL  
PRICE: \$379.95  
NILE'S RATING:  
7/10**